

KF6 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

I am going to read our opening prayer using Karis Fellowships vocabulary: “Examine me, O God, and reveal my motivations. Run experiments on me and expose my misoriented thinking. See if there is any hurtful or idolatrous way in me, and lead me in ways that will last forever.”

Take a deep breath.

Oriented thinking is essential for personal growth and physical well-being. Our minds and bodies are designed to function together in harmony, but we are rarely taught how to create that harmony. Although we may not be aware of it, our bodies inform our thinking, and our thinking is often related to trauma that is stored chemically and energetically in our bodies. The physiological reality is that distressed bodies result in distressed minds. When the body is distressed, it sends chemical signals to the brain that cause our minds to react, and often overreact, in a simple and primitive attempt to survive.

You can calm your mind by first calming your body. That’s why, in KF, we start with mindfulness training. Daily mindfulness practice trains our bodies to calm down in those moments when we find ourselves in stressful situations that invite compulsive and addictive choices. These are the emergencies, the times when you are heating up or melting down. In these experiments, choose mindfulness, even for a few seconds, to help calm your body, open your mind to the truth, and free your creativity. If your body’s alarm system is calmed down, you can think creatively when you most need to.

We will now learn a new meditation practice taught by John Main, OSB. This Roman Catholic monk noticed that a Buddhist priest had more peace than he did, and he learned that the priest’s secret was meditation. You can read about John Main’s work and history on the web. He writes,

The all-important aim in Christian meditation is to allow God’s mysterious and silent presence within us to become more and more not only *a* reality, but *the* reality which gives meaning, shape and purpose to everything we do, to everything we are.¹

It has taken me several years of practice to experience what he describes, but that effort has been

worthwhile. Meditation is “dose dependent”—the more you practice, the more you benefit.

The Maranatha Meditation²

This is how John Main presents this meditation:

Sit down. Sit still and upright. Close your eyes lightly. Sit relaxed, but alert. Silently, interiorly begin to say a single word. We recommend the prayer-phrase *maranatha*. Recite it as four syllables of equal length. Listen to it as you say it, gently but continuously. Do not think or imagine anything—spiritual or otherwise. If thoughts or images come, these are distractions at the time of meditation, so keep returning to simply saying the word. Meditate each morning and evening for between twenty and thirty minutes.³

We always begin our meditation practice by sitting upright and as still as possible. If you are ill or fatigued, you can sit propped up with pillows. Try sitting up as if you were waiting for someone or something that is just around the corner. *(Pause)* Breathe as you lightly close your eyes. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Silently, within your own mind, begin to slowly say the word MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA. *Maranatha* is an Aramaic word that is used as a prayer in the Bible.⁴ You can let it roll on the breath like the swell of the sea, or you can simply focus on each syllable for a second or two. Remember to breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

As you say the word within yourself, attend to the word. Listen to it within your mind throughout the meditation time. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* If your mind wanders, gently draw it back to the word. We will focus on MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA for one minute. Try to let go of the sense of passing time and just relax into the word. Begin. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now pause and take a few deep breaths as you open your eyes. Gently draw your mind back to the meeting. *(Pause)* Through meditation, we train our mind, body, will, and heart to be still and to wait upon the Lord in any situation, no matter what is happening in us or around us.

Our hymn and prayer is *Breathe on Me, Breath of God*.

Breathe on me, Breath of God,
Until my heart is pure,
Until with Thee I will one will,
To do and to endure.⁵

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

During these past weeks, we have been exploring KF Confession 1:

We confess that we have worshipped and served an Idol Self that we have created.

We will now move on to KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by our Creator.

In this Confession, we admit that when our Idol Self is in charge, we readily abandon the glory that God designed for us.

I hope that you have a copy of the **Two Paths Flowchart** in front of you.

Training ourselves takes time, and so does healing. In this fast-paced world, we often cannot accept the limitation of time. It takes time to learn how to use KF tools, so you must think about adjusting your schedule to create space for practice and soul care. If you do not schedule time to care for yourself, you will wear yourself out in this training process. Like any craftsman who regularly uses his tools, you will learn to work faster, more efficiently, and more effectively toward your healing if you practice—and, also, if you rest.

Training is a seasonal cycle of endurance and rest. As you endure your training, keep the promise of James 1:4 in mind: “Allow endurance to accomplish its purpose that you may grow up and be complete, lacking nothing, fully equipped for your joy and mission.” As you rest, review your **Meeting Preparation Guides**. Congratulate yourself for the progress you have made.

Let’s review the KF tools that we are learning to use. These tools help us continue to make progress even when we feel discouraged, frustrated, or stuck.

1. **KF weekly meetings and the Meeting Preparation Guide**

In the Karis Fellowships meetings you are trained, healed, and reminded of your disciplines. These meetings guide your training efforts and give you a chance to share the progress and challenges that you have recorded on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. Sharing your battles and discoveries with others is essential for your healing.

2. **Our manuals—the Bible and the book *Neurosis and Human Growth*⁶**

You may be starting to see how these two resources work together to guide you back to your design and mission.

3. **Mindfulness and meditation practice**

Mindfulness training teaches you to observe with your mind, calm your body, and exercise endurance, all of which strengthens your True Self.

4. **Worksheets and guides—homework for lasting recovery**

These worksheets and guides can be found on the KF website under **Toolbox**. You can start exploring them at any time. Ask your Karis Link to help you choose a worksheet or guide that might be useful in your situation. You might also attend additional training groups where you can practice using KF worksheets.

5. **The Tapping Protocol⁷**

Here is our quote from Robert Louis Stevenson: “You cannot run away from weakness; you must at some time fight it out or perish; and if that be so, why not now, and where you stand?”⁸ Tapping is one way to fight it out against the weakness of your fear. After a few months of training, you will be

able to quickly detect the fear, feel the strain within you, and tap. Under trial, when your endurance is giving out, excuse yourself from the situation and calm yourself with a tap. With a calmer body, you can think straight about what is real and what you really want. You can then make creative choices toward healthier outcomes.

6. The Two Paths Flowchart

This valuable tool reveals the path you have taken in a situation—the path of judgment or the path of agape love. It can also help you learn to choose love. If you want the Fruit of the Spirit to shine through your life, you will have to give up the judgments that fuel your Idol Self, and learn to dwell in real love.

Hopefully, you have been able to look at the **Two Paths Flowchart**. In our KF training, we have begun to identify our fears and the events that trigger those fears. In addition to fearful reactions, reactions of euphoria also send us down a dangerous path. Mindless euphoria is the result of judging that something is extraordinarily good. This strong emotion puts us in the Idol's hands because we become forgetful. We lose touch with our limitations and weaknesses as creatures. We forget that we need maintenance and soul care. We forget what has happened in the past. We think that the euphoria indicates new potential, and we mindlessly take on challenges that are beyond our abilities. Then, when reality catches up with us, we are completely blindsided and fall.

The two paths of the flowchart represent the dualities that we see in the Bible—spirit and flesh, life and death, Jesus and Adam, righteousness and unrighteousness, wisdom from above and wisdom from below, and many more. The upper path is the path of the True Self and the lower path is the path of the Idol Self. In the next few weeks, I will be introducing a worksheet that will help you to understand and use this chart.

Look at the flowchart this week and try to notice when you are taking the lower path as you go through your day. What is the event? What assault on your Idol's search for glory has disconnected you from God and thrown you into fear? It may help to remember that if your reaction is extreme, it is probably fear-driven. Did you judge the event as good or evil? What story are you telling about yourself, about others, or about life? What emotions are then justified by that story? What choices are you making based on those emotions? What is the outcome of your choices? Play with the flowchart this week and see what you can discover about yourself.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Guide and Friend, reveal to me the path that I have taken. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's return to the first chapter of James. I hope that you have printed out this chapter and have the text in front of you. We will review what we have learned in the last few meetings, and then I would like to talk a little about agape love and describe what this love looks like for Christians.

This is my translation of our text for this lesson, **James 1:2–4**.

²Guide yourselves into all joy, my siblings, when you fall into and are surrounded by all kinds of experiments, ³knowing that these experiments examine what you trust and act upon. They also grow your ability to remain under examination in future experiments, experiments that will further explore your ever-expanding potential. ⁴Give this growing ability of endurance a chance to accomplish its purpose, which is to make you a mature and complete person, lacking nothing, fully equipped for your joy and mission.

Take a deep breath.

1. The struggle is the valuable part of our process

It is only in the struggle that we develop endurance and courage. Endurance without judgment gives us the creative space that allows us to learn how to build a glorious life and a karis relationship with God. Keep in mind that our most productive struggle is against our Idol Self—not against others or against the Creation. Our pride wants to “get it right” the first time, but we learn humility when we have to struggle to “get it right”. The humbling process of struggle disables our pride system and invites God to be our ally, whereas the easy achievement of goals often feeds our pride. Only when we have effectively dealt with our pride can we successfully handle the rewards of our achievements. Immanuel Kant, who is considered to be the father of modern philosophy,⁹ taught that *struggle is the indispensable accompaniment of progress*.¹⁰ (*Repeat*). Our popular culture has certainly strayed from that belief! Christians, however, are not bound by that culture and are invited by God to learn to struggle well. So, let’s learn how to struggle well.

We actually become stronger, healthier, and more resilient by engaging with manageable, productive, and intermittent struggle with its attendant stressors. In our physical bodies, this revitalizing process is called *hormesis*; when it happens in our souls, it is called sanctification.¹¹

2. The discovery and fostering of our True Self requires a lot of endurance

Any kind of growth requires a sustained effort in a consistent direction. That takes courage. For example, Karis Fellowships itself is the result of courageous sustained effort over decades. Without the courage and endurance of several people, we would not be here. As you begin to discover your True Self, you will feel fear because you are going into the not-knowing and abandoning your search for glory. If something goes wrong, if the path isn’t easy, or if you are uncomfortable and feel that fear again, you will need courage to withstand the temptation to run back to your old patterns of reacting. You will also need courage to endure your self-hate long enough to manage it productively, first by recognizing that you are in self-hate and then by using your KF tools. Your tools will help you hold an oriented course instead of escaping into compulsive addictive behaviors or imposing frantic claims on others and on life.

3. Let endurance have its perfect result

What is endurance? The Greek word translated as *endurance* means to *remain under*. It means to resist running away. Running away looks different for different Idol types. A mastery type runs away by self-assertion or grabbing control. A self-effacing type runs away by appeasing and complying. A resigned type just runs. It takes faith, or trust, to stand and resist running away. We learn that productive endurance is *for us*; it plays a crucial role in developing our True Self and revealing our real glory. All kinds of experiences put our faith under the microscope; we get to see where we have placed our trust. Are we trusting God and His love, or are we trusting the Idol Self and its fears?

While we remain under the tension of the experiment, we become creative. We become aware, we explore, we use tools, and we get help. We learn that productive endurance is *for* us; it plays a crucial role in developing our True Self and revealing our real glory.

In the old days of photography, light striking the film changed the nature of the film's coating, but that change could not be seen until the film was developed. For this reason, the film had to go into a developing bath—a kind of baptism, if you will—where it underwent a process that revealed the latent or photographed image. The film would then go into a fixing bath where the image on the film became permanent. You are going through a similar process. Your nature has also been changed; it has been changed by the light of Jesus shining on your soul. You are no longer a creature of darkness, full of the fears and the pride that set you in opposition to your Creator. You have been recreated by the power of the Spirit to live in the light. But who will be able to see what Jesus has imprinted on your soul unless you courageously go through the development process? And how will you consistently display that new image if you haven't spent enough time in regular training to make those changes enduring? The goal of our KF work is to produce in our lives the permanent image of our spiritual rebirth. Your spiritual rebirth is revealed when you consistently display the Fruit of the Spirit, giving evidence of a lasting change in your character. You can choose to avoid the training that leads to lasting fruit, but if you do, you will never experience the transforming power of Jesus in and through your life. As a consequence, the unique manifestation of His splendor that you were designed to reveal will never be displayed. On the other hand, you can choose to *remain under*, that is, to endure your training until the image of Christ is revealed to the world through you.

Most of us were not trained to endure productively. We endured only to support the agenda of the people around us or to indulge their comfort—in other words, to pacify their Idol Self. This kind of endurance was not about developing our potential but about satisfying someone else's compulsive needs. We suffered without any benefit to ourselves. The society in which we live does not want us to endure. Quite the contrary. It promotes the values of instant gratification, relief from all discomfort, and doing whatever it takes to get our own way. Our culture tells us that we deserve better, and we deserve it now! However, neither wallowing in our culture's self-indulgent values nor subordinating our needs to the needs of others can teach us the productive endurance that builds loving, glorious lives. Now, through our KF training, we have tools that make endurance beneficial and even profitable, not only for ourselves but also for this world.

Let's switch gears a little and look at an aspect of agape love that is similar to endurance. The passage that describes Christian agape is found in First Corinthians, chapter 13. First of all, love is *makrothumos*.¹² That is the Greek word for this quality. Makrothumos is listed first because without it we cannot develop the other qualities of love. Makrothumos means *long-tempered* as opposed to *short-tempered*. It is sometimes translated as *long-suffering*. When you choose long-suffering, however, you are not choosing to just suffer for a long time. Makrothumos is strategic. It has a purpose in view and uses your discomfort to achieve that purpose.

In KF, you are learning to welcome the way that life runs all kinds of experiments on you. God uses these trials as opportunities to reveal where your trust lies, where your heart is. You are learning to grow out of your illusions and habitual ways of reacting. You are training yourself to trust God and to respond with positive action in every situation. You are learning to take care of your True Self. Ultimately, your goal is to learn to be long-tempered no matter how you feel—to refuse the easy path of giving in to your tensions, to resist running away, and, instead, to be strategic in thought, word, and action. When your True Self is connected to the Holy Spirit, you can trust God when others are panicking, snatching, controlling, or

hysterical. You know what that looks like—going out of control to get control. It is fear, once again, paralyzing people and driving them to mindlessly resist, manipulate, or attack.

Do you want to live without fear? The Apostle John tells us that only love can cast out fear.¹³ In Karis Fellowships, we are learning to be people of no fear who are becoming the love of God in this sorry world.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, help me allow Your love to cast out my fear. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a situation in which you cannot love yourself or someone else. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider a situation in which you cannot love yourself or someone else, how does it feel? (Pause) Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush thoughts and feelings from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your thoughts and feelings up to the light as you *consider a situation in which you cannot love yourself or someone else. (Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider this situation in which you cannot love yourself or someone else*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what frustration or hatred feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this situation in which you cannot love yourself or someone else*. Do you feel comfortable with Jesus, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Have you judged yourself or this situation as good or evil? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Is your experience a regular pattern in your life? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of loss, of deprivation, of others, or of yourself? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when you cannot love. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for every other human being who feels like you do when you cannot love. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause and take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for this time together of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

The KF book study of *Honor, Patronage, Kinship, and Purity* (HPKP) by Dr. David deSilva is in progress. This study has helped many KF members explore the integrity of their own Christian beliefs in the context of first century values and culture.

¹ John Main, *Silence and Stillness in Every Season: Daily Readings with John Main*, ed. Paul Harris (New York: Continuum International Publishing Group, 1997), 2.

² John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

³ Ibid.

⁴ 1 Cor. 16:22; Rev. 22:20.

⁵ *Breathe on Me, Breath of God* by Edwin Hatch (1835-1889), www.youtube.com/watch?v=M5keJHZdWYM.

⁶ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁷ Dr. Roger Callahan, “TFT Stress Buster Tapping Class-Learn to Use TFT Tapping,” Callahan Techniques, accessed April 24, 2016, www.rogercallahan.com/learn-to-tap.php. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

⁸ "Robert Louis Stevenson Quotes," *Goodreads*, accessed April 24, 2016, www.goodreads.com/author/quotes/854076.Robert_Louis_Stevenson.

⁹ *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, s.v. "Immanuel Kant," last modified January 25, 2016, plato.stanford.edu/entries/kant.

¹⁰ Will Durant, *The Story of Philosophy: The Lives and Opinions of the World's Greatest Philosophers from Plato to John Dewey* (New York: Pocket Books, 2006), 366.

¹¹ www.definitions.net/definition/hormesis; 1 Pet. 1:1-25.

¹² 1 Cor. 13:4.

¹³ 1 John 4:18.a